Report on the Australian Sound Design Project

Dr Ros Bandt with Iain Mott

The Australian Sound Design Project is a nationwide initiative to document on the web the works of Australian sound designers who work in public space. It was intitiated by Dr Ros Bandt through an ARC large grant and is hosted by the interdisciplinary Australian Centre at the University of Melbourne where she is honorary senior fellow. The research assistants, originally Garth Paine, and now Iain Mott facilitate the project, managing the database and web site programming and design.

The aims and objectives of the Australian Sound Design Project are published on the website, http://www.sounddesign.unimelb.edu.au on the ABOUT page and more fully in the paper given at the Waveform Conference at the launch of this project last year. Designing public acoustic space: Australian sound designs, a database and website, for a more considered acoustic environment is published on the website under papers.

I reiterate an invitation to all sound designers to be part of this project, visit the site and complete the online form and become part of the first Australia wide network in sound design. It is also a free multi-media publishing opportunity. The questionnaire and copyright deed must be filled out and there is an electronic form on line. Hard copies can also be sent.

The ASDP has become a serious resource as well as a source of documentation. The powerful database of over 500 people has a search facility by designer and by sound designs or site or date. It includes all those practitioners who work in the field of designing sound in public space, artists, curators, electronic programmers, software and audio engineers, and all forms of acoustic designers. Two works from each artist have been requested and these are being designed for the web at the present time. Over 50 artists have responded with original materials so far. As well as publishing the sound designs in multi media formats of images, video, sound, text and graphics, it also contains a powerful list of research tools, including important unpublished papers, (Carter, Belfrage, Atwell), a list of Australian and international links, links about sound, links to the sites of sound artists who have their own sites, a list of software and on-line tools, and a comprehensive bibliography. Since its inception the site has received 35,690 hits.

On a technical level, the project is currently adding design and designer information to a database that can generate web pages with sophisticated cross-referencing and browsing capacity. The database is called the Online Heritage Resource Manager developed by the Australian Science and Technology Heritage Centre (www.austehc.unimelb.edu.au). Browsing will be performed by alphabetical listings of entries as well as by category, for example searching by designer, curator, host or funding body. In addition, users will be able to access information through two separate search mechanisms. The first utilises software called ht://Dig . This indexes web files and enables simple keyword searches. The second makes use of PHP scripting and a server-side database containing information duplicated from the primary database maintained at the Australian Centre. This system allows for advanced searches utilising individual fields within the database. Individuals will be able to search for entries using a selection of criteria.

The ASDP has established the first comprehensive resource about sound in Australia and is a powerful research, publishing and networking facility. Be part of it by filling out the on line form:

http://www.sounddesign.unimelb.edu.au/site/InvitationLetter.html

Biographies

Dr Ros Bandt, ARC director of the Australian Sound Design Project, a nation wide data base and website, author of 3 books on spatial sound design in Australian artworks and internationally acclaimed sound artist, composer and performer.

Iain Mott, is a Melbourne based sound artist.He has exhibited nationally in Australia and internationally at exhibitions including the Ars Electronica. Iain was the Artist in Residence at the CSIRO Mathematical and Informations Sciences.